

ing sexual harassment at least once but less than half officially reported the incident to their employer, as per the study. This gap between experience and reporting is not rooted in ignorance of the law, but in fear of consequences such as being labelled “difficult”, jeopardising team dynamics, harming career opportunities, or facing subtle retaliation masked as performance feedback.

One of the most significant barriers to addressing the male gaze is the normalisation of subtle behaviours. Many women rationalise discomfort, often subconsciously, because questioning it feels confrontational in a culture that values deference and respect for hierarchy.

Mala Bhandari, Founder-Director, Social and Development Research and Action Group (SADRAG) and PoSH consultant, highlights the need for education. “Many women struggle to differentiate between workplace harassment and sexual harassment. Sensitisation via workshops is essential and men must be equal participants in these conversations,” she says.

Interestingly, hybrid workplaces saw a rise in digital forms of boundary violation with unnecessary video calls, late-night messages, and comments during virtual meetings framed around appearance or body language. The male gaze adapted, but so did the vigilance of ICs, who now treat digital behaviour with equal seriousness.

For meaningful change, organisations must look beyond the legal minimum. “It’s about respect. It’s about trust. It’s about creating a safe environment, and it starts with leaders. They have to walk the talk,” says Shilpa Vora, Chief R&D Officer, Marico Ltd.

Suman Mishra, MD and CEO of Mahindra Last Mile Mobility Limited, highlights how her organisation adheres to a zero-tolerance attitude towards sexual harassment to enable a safe environment for women. “I believe that culture is built basis day-to-day behaviour which provides both physical and psychological safety,” adds Mishra.

Pardeshi seconds this, as zero tolerance is crucial to provide a safe space to file complaints. Women often hold back thinking about how their family might react, fearing future victimisation at the workplace, and doubting their career progression.

Since the implementation of PoSH norms in 2013, there has undeniably been a shift. Cases are being reported more openly, awareness around workplace harassment has grown, and women are steadily reclaiming their agency in professional spaces, buoyed by policies that finally do more than exist on paper.

Bhasin notes this shift most clearly in metros and Tier I cities, where women are no longer holding back and speak up with the confidence of knowing they are pro-



“When women feel constantly scrutinised, they self-edit, and organisations lose tremendous potential.”

SULAJJA FIRODIA MOTWANI
FOUNDER & CEO, KINETIC GREEN



“Self-confidence is critical. When the right women are in the right roles—like STEM—it becomes about capability and ability, and no longer about the male gaze.”

SHILPA VORA
CHIEF R&D OFFICER,
MARICO LTD.

| 151

tected. She is now seeing similarly bold reporting in many Tier II and Tier III locations as well. “The key is ensuring women feel safe to call out misconduct without fear of retaliation,” she says.

A broader shift is also essential, and any meaningful workplace change occurs only when women are present across levels of hierarchy. Representation normalises authority, challenges stereotypes, and gradually disarms the male gaze.

The problem of enabling environment cannot be solved by punitive action alone. It is embedded in systems, language, humour, hiring patterns, performance norms, and unspoken codes of workplace behaviour. It thrives in ambiguity, silence, and the fear of appearing “oversensitive”.

For India Inc., the task is not only to spot misconduct but to undo a culture where women are constantly negotiating visibility with safety.

Ultimately, a workplace free of the male gaze is not just safer for women but it is stronger, fairer, and more future-ready for everyone. **BT**

@octoprash